



Escaping the war

GIs exchange heroin vials in a decorated bunk in Vietnam. Opium and heroin were cheap, and of a high quality, but used primarily in secure areas because their narcotic effect could get the user killed.

» AFTER

Studies of Vietnam veterans indicated that drug use primarily stemmed from combat exposure and that 90 percent of veterans stopped using drugs upon their return to the United States.

NEGATIVE IMAGES

Although the Nixon administration tried to downplay the military's concerns about drug use, **popular stereotypes** began to emerge back home of service members as "potheads" and drug addicts. These images were inaccurate overall, but sadly heroin addiction did afflict many **returning service men and women**, who often struggled to get the help they needed.